User Research Protocol

Overall Methodology: To better understand where friction and pain points may lie in the current user experience of the Madison County elections website, I have asked my representative users to access the website and interact with it as if they fell into one of two separate cases:

1. Someone who knows that they are not registered to vote in and has never voted in Madison County before. They are looking for information on how to register to vote, where to do so, where their polling location is, election day information, and any other information they may find pertinent to the task of trying to vote in a new county for the first time.

2. Someone who has previously been registered to vote and has voted in Madison County, but is unsure of whether or not they still are registered. Subsequently, once figuring out if they are still registered or not and rectifying that if necessary, looking for that same general election information, i.e. dates, times, locations they can vote, candidates up for election, etc.

For both cases, I also encouraged my representative users to seek out additional information on alternative voting methods, such as vote by mail or early voting. Furthermore, I encouraged them to explore the website as much as they wanted past the primary tasks I gave them. I wanted them to try to cover as many potential use cases and user scenarios as possible.

Notes: Any text that is surrounded with quotation marks and that is italicized are direct quotes from the subject, otherwise it's me paraphrasing/observing them using the website.

Additionally, I will take screenshots to demonstrate what my representative users are talking about and reference them as **(Image X)** *in that same bolded format. The X will be a number that changes depending on the image referenced, and the images will be shown at the end of the Data Collection section.*

Data Collection

Subject Name: Lauren Wilcox
Case Type: Definite unregistered voter trying to vote in Madison County for the first time
Observation Date: 10/6/26

- *"The banner at the top is ginormous. I have to scroll down before I can even start to see most of the information. Does it really have to be this big?"* **(Image 1)**
- *"My screen is filled with so much clutter"*
    - When asked to identify what she means, she listed: the overall Madison County drop down menus at the top that don't have anything to do with voting, the big banner previously mentioned, a pop up about "TextMyGov elections" in the bottom right of the page, the "share" button on the right, the sub banner that includes subscribing for page updates and a "Search Our County…" text entry field. **(Image 1)**
- After scrolling down, negatively reacted to the varied images showing "Candidate Information," "Voter Services," "Early Voting," and "Interactive Maps Polling Places & Voting Districts" **(Image 2)**
- She noticed accessibility settings in the bottom left and tried turning on "Highlight links", but that did not highlight the links contained in the images **(Image 3)**
- She tried to use the "Bigger Text" function in the Accessibility Menu and it did make the text bigger, but it seemingly also zoomed in and somewhat broke the design of the website **(Image 4)**
- *"There is no button to "register to vote". Where can I do that?"*
- After some searching, she realized that if you hover over "Voters" on the left hand side, a dropdown menu appears that has "Voter Registration" inside of it.
- Once you click on that link, there is a page that includes a blue hyper link called "Click here to Register to Vote Online". Underneath this hyperlink, there are a lot of drop down menus with information on how to register to vote **(Image 5)**
    - Clicking on this hyperlink takes you to an alternate website in a new tab: ova.elections.il.gov
- Once on the alternate website, she entered her information and was able to successfully get to the final page, where it asked her to confirm her information.
    - I noticed that this website had very low contrast between its black text and gray/beige backgrounds.
    - The website does offer different languages in the top right

Subject Name: Jackson Gibbons
Case Type: Previous Madison County voter, checking registration status and general election information.
Observation Date: 10/7/26

- Similarly reacted negatively to the outdated and cluttered design of the website
- *"This looks like it was made over a decade ago"*
- *"What are these pictures doing in the middle of the page after I scroll down? this looks really unprofessional"*
- Clicked on the "Voter Services" image that contains a link that took him to a separate page **(Image 6)**
- He returned to the main page because he thought this wasn't going to get him to what he wanted: checking his voter registration status.
- After poking around for about a minute, he found the drop down menu on the left under "Voters".
    - In here, there is a drop down menu for "Am I registered to Vote?" that contains a hyperlink that says "Verify my registration"
        - It takes you to the same page as "Voter Services" does **(Image 6)**
- **POST OBSERVATION:** Now that I am adding photos afterwards, I don't want to use his information, but when using mine, it says "No match found" and is giving me these goofy tips to try to make the search work. **(Image 7)**. It also redirects me to another website with a hyperlink of "Voter LIsts" if it's still unsuccessful. Why no dropdowns with road names here? Seems like bad design to me
- He found that he is indeed registered to vote still
- Going back out, he wanted to look into vote by mail as he travels for work a lot and may not be present in the county during the election. Now that he was becoming more accustomed to the website, he was quickly able to find this subpage in the left sidebar under the name "Vote By Mail"
- *"I like the drop down menus based on questions and categories of people"* **(Image 8)**
- He looked at the polling places interactive map from the left sidebar as well because I asked him to keep poking around a little more **(Image 9)**. This does send you to an alternate GIS website: https://gisportal.co.madison.il.us/portal/apps/webappviewer/index.html?id=36b1e164b1c541db8e4082ec39116b52



Image 1

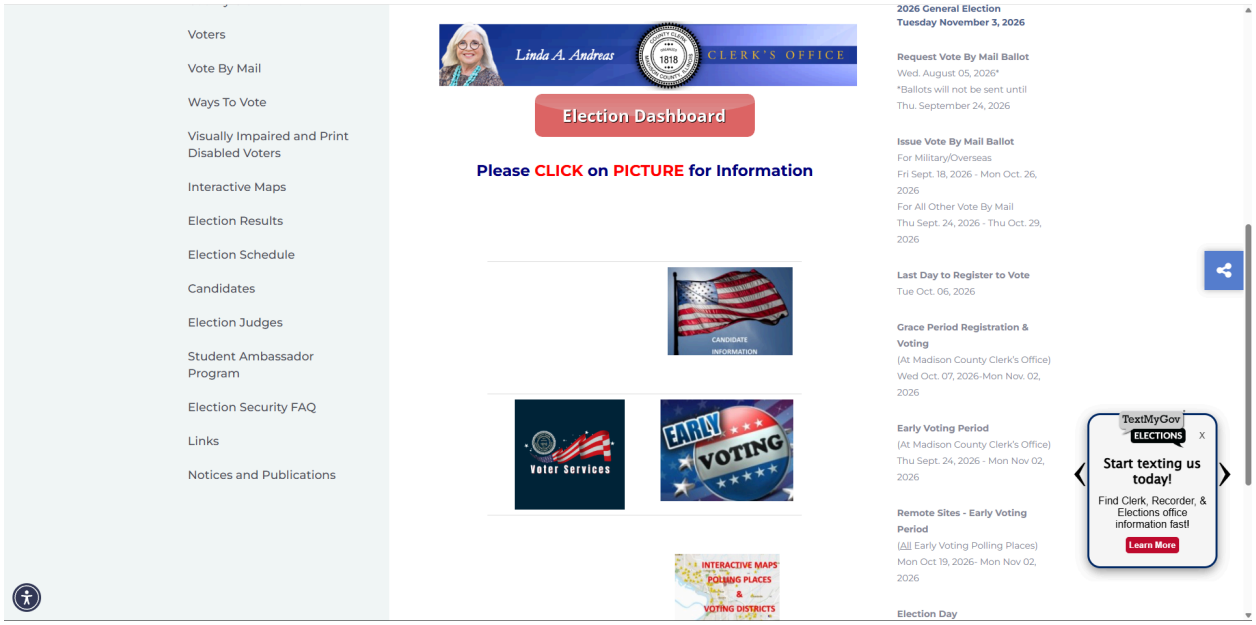


Image 2

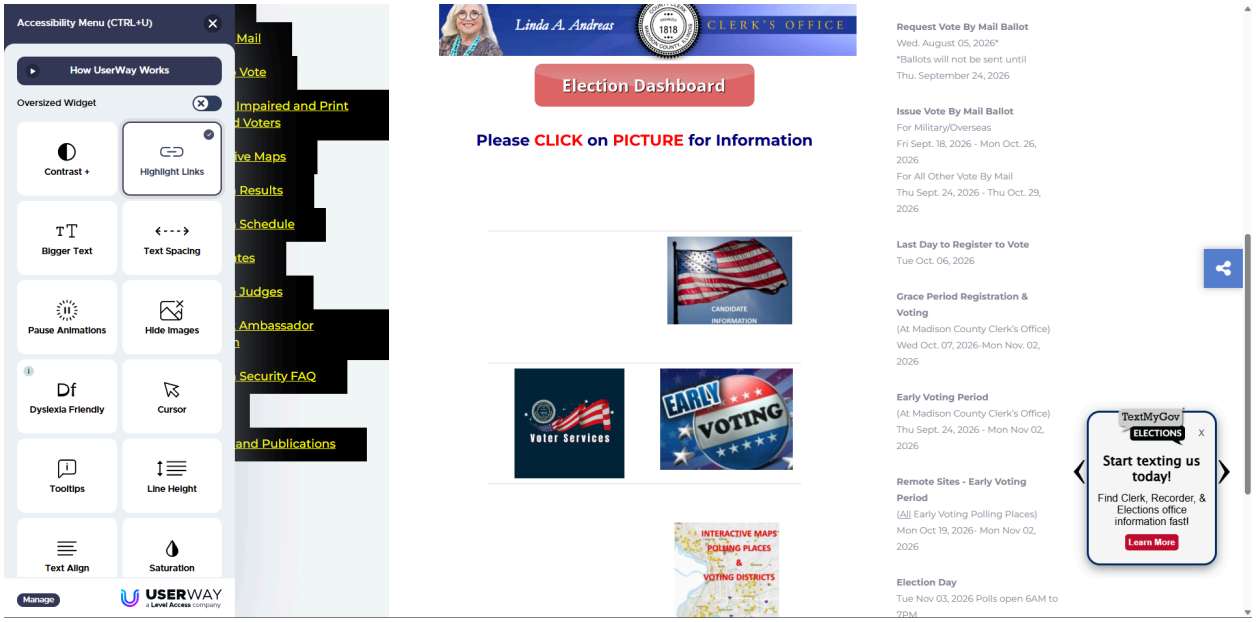


Image 3

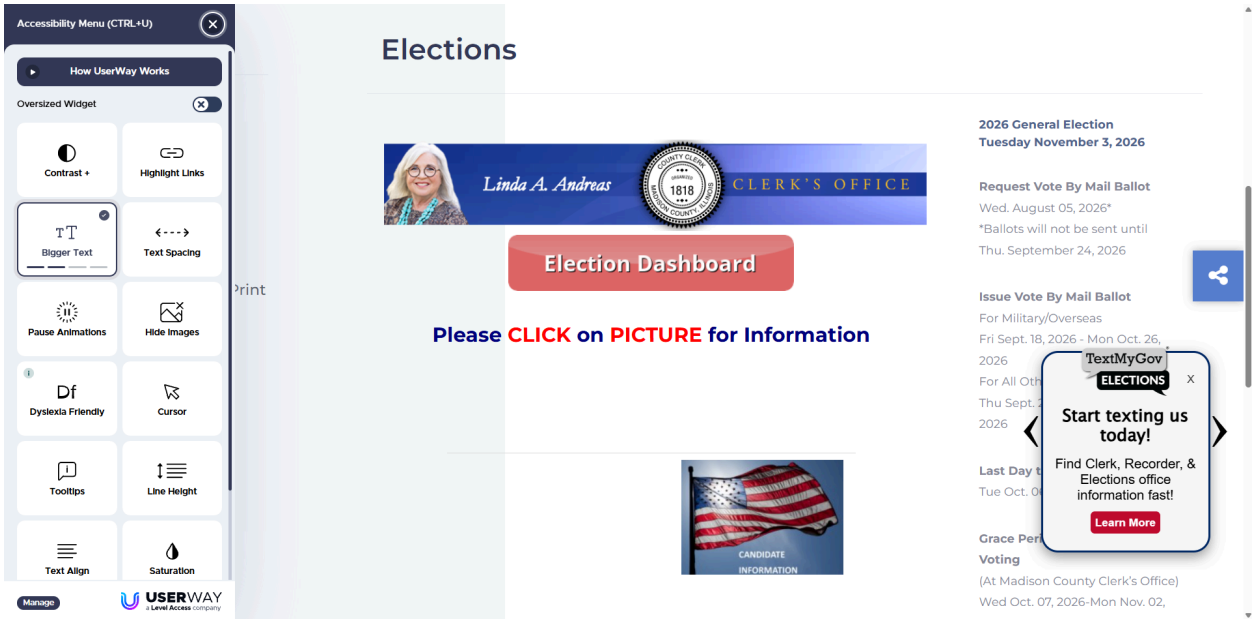


Image 4

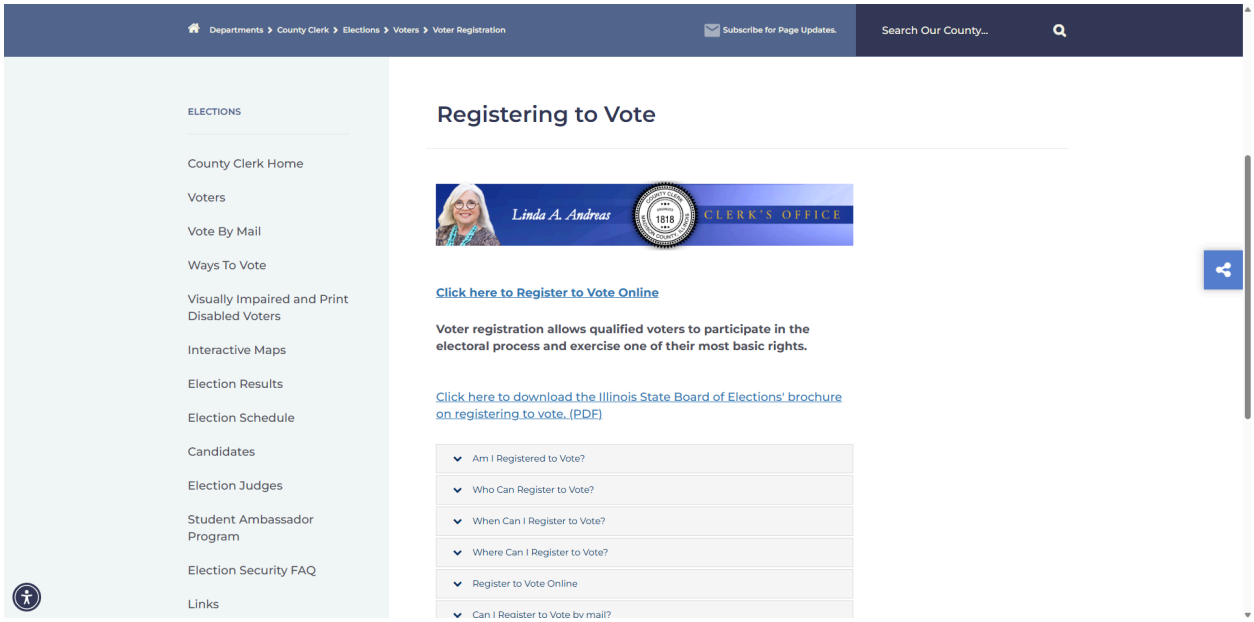


Image 5

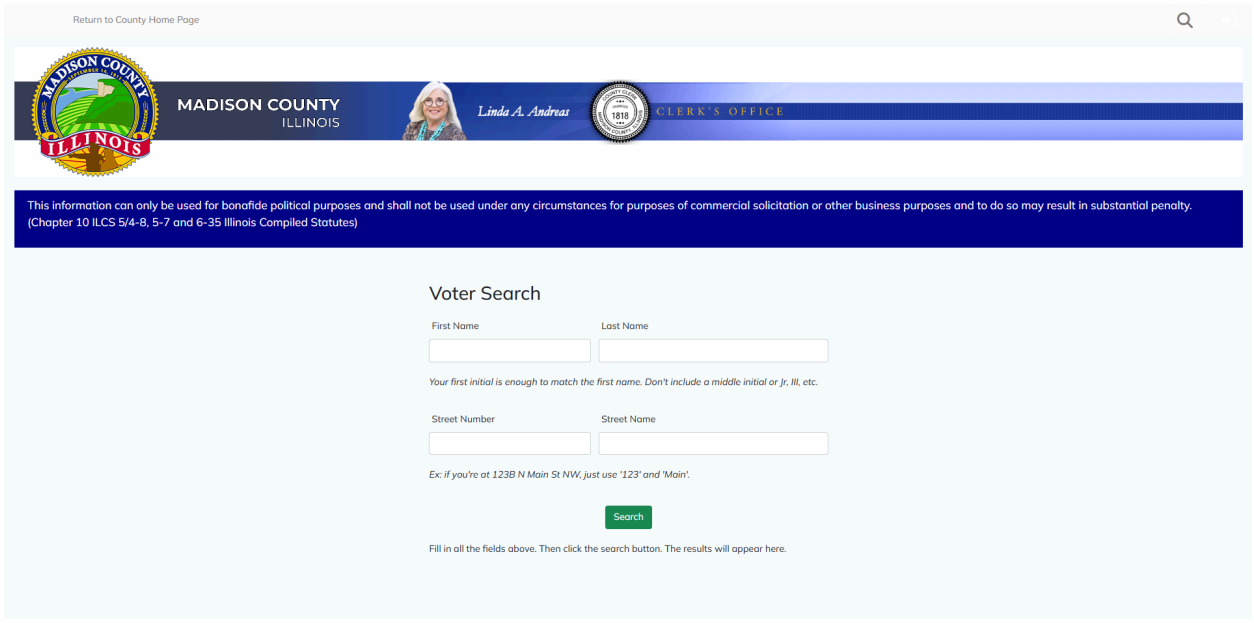


Image 6

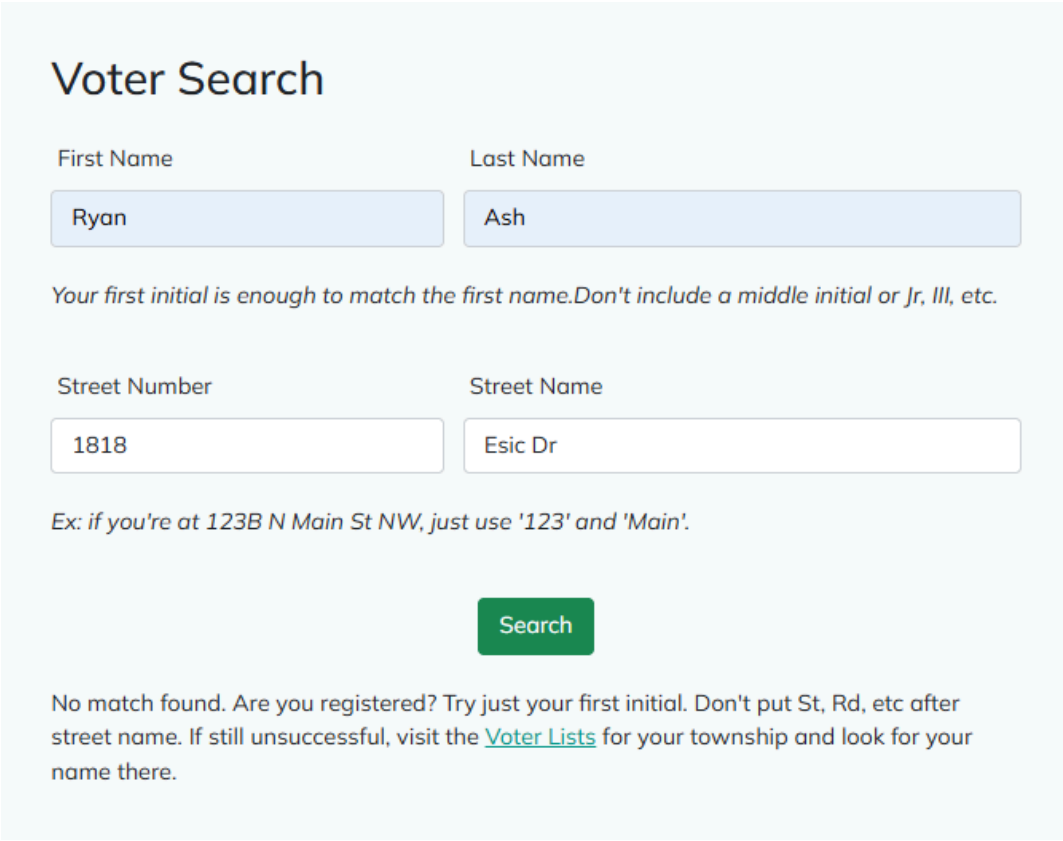


Image 7 - NOTE: Using my own information as I don't want to compromise my subject's privacy

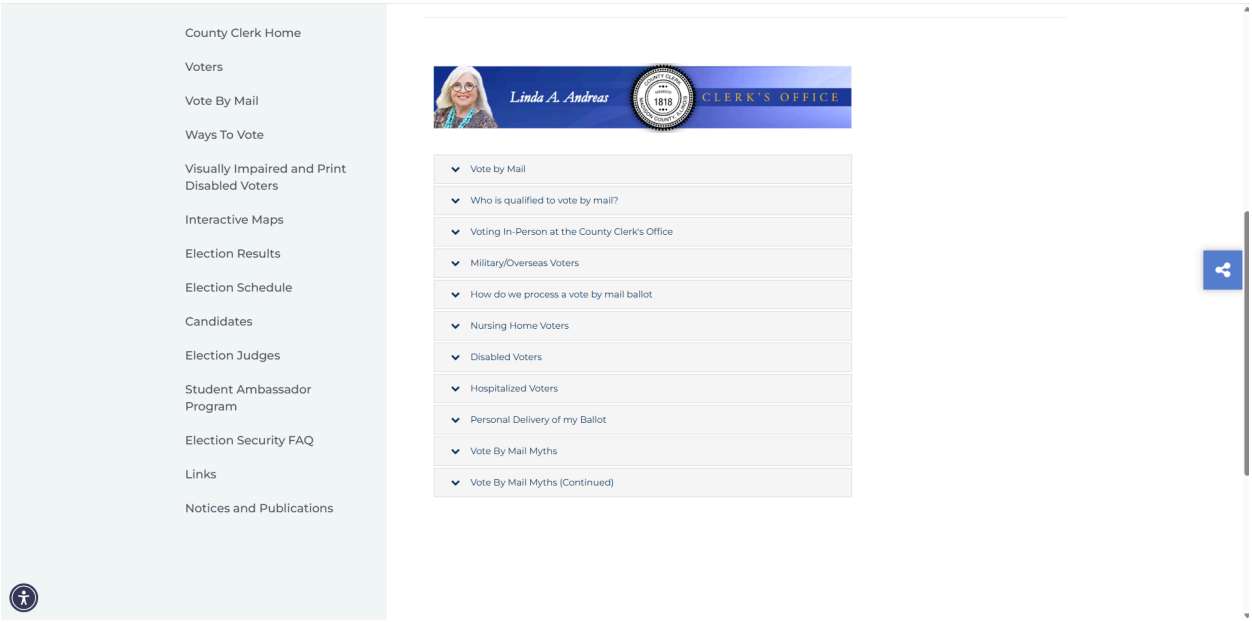


Image 8

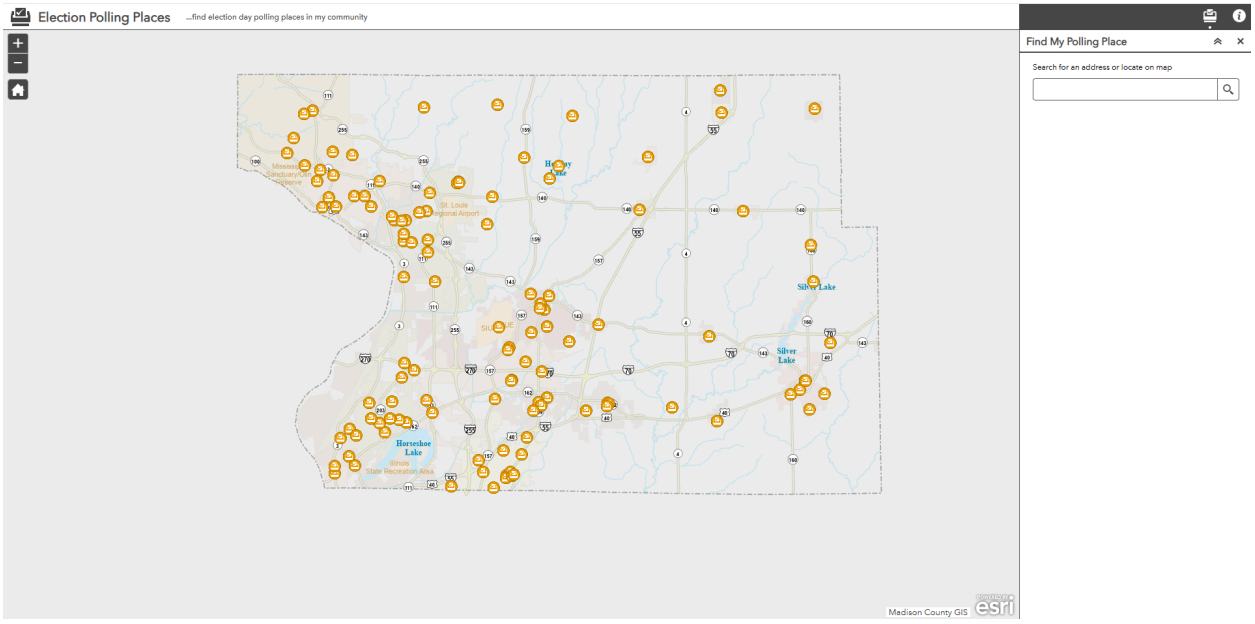

Election Polling Places
...find election day polling places in my community
Find My Polling Place
Search for an address or locate on map
Horseshoe Lake
Silver Lake
Madison County GIS
esri

Image 9

Synthesis

- One of the common and immediate throughlines between my two observational subjects was how the site is ugly, outdated, and cluttered.
    - There is definitely high cognitive load when you first enter the site. There is just so much going on on your screen and both subjects had to take a second to even understand what they were looking at.
    - Over time as they got used to the site, they were able to navigate it more fluidly, but we shouldn't be satisfied with that. A brand new user should be able to come to the site and immediately feel at ease with it.
- The hyperlink images are goofy and unbecoming of an official government website.
    - The text on them is low contrast in certain instances, the images form a strange "T" shape on the page, and they seem to link to pages that you can get to elsewhere through less archaic means. Redundant.
- The fact that there is no visual indication that the "Voters" text contains a drop down menu inside of it until you hover over it is silly. There should be a little upward facing triangle next to it that turns to the right as you mouse over it so that users can understand there are more links hidden there. This caused my second subject, Jackson, to not be able to find the page he was in search of for a few minutes - bad design.
- There are a lot of hyperlinks that open a new tab and take you to another website. If possible, it'd be nice if more of these functions could be included into the current website. I think older or less experienced computer users might get confused by constantly having new tabs open and take them away from where they were without warning.
- The accessibility settings in the bottom left seem insufficient at best and performative at worst. It looks like some third party company the county is using to try to meet some kind of compliance standards. I think they would better serve disabled communities by hiring an independent HCI consultant to create the accessibility features specifically for this website.
- The banner + other Madison County functions at the top of the page are unruly and unnecessary. If someone is specifically looking for information about voting, the first look at the elections page shouldn't contain 50% non-voting or non-pertinent information.
- No offense to her, but do we need Linda A. Andreas's face + banner + the county clerk seal on every single page? Seems like needless clutter